

Critical Reflection on Gender as of Wednesday, 10th September 2022  
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It is hard to consider or find practical examples of architectural practice within these texts, but in itself this may be the point. Women by nature are less interested in the practical and more interested in the experience.

The canon in architecture is strictly surrounding construction and rigid developments that offer very little room for recognition of “lesser” practices.

The ambiguity and lateral nature of the cosmic feminine ideology is precisely what the profession lacks, and this is difficult for us to grasp because of the way architecture has been perceived and taught. We are a long way from realising feminist architecture, whatever that may look like - even considering that it may already exist in ways unrecognisable to us.

Like most of the readings in the course, feminist theory begins to describe a state of mind less so than an explicit set of design ideals, but there are naturally suggestions as to what should be prioritised from the female perspective.

The process of feminine design is that which experiments and engages and involves multiple figures with a lesser priority on the self-identity in a project. The sense of ego in the building is smaller, and hence often manifests in smaller and simply scales, designs, aesthetics, and even simpler solutions.

It is interesting to note that many ethnic cultures and design processes involve the use of feminine orders and thinking - it would not be a stretch to say that many of these cultural values have been forced out of use by the imposition of colonialism and by extension, capitalist modern development.

Christopher Alexander studied patterns and unit to whole concepts from African cosmology, which centered around the matriarchal concepts of the divine and hence, the culture and its designs developed accordingly.

Arguably, pattern language, lateral thinking, formation of creative connections and use of subjective emotion; are all feminine characteristics that have presented itself in African indigenous theory, as well as Feminist literature like that of Matrix's “Making Space.”

The relationship between decolonisation and feminism is hence intersectional, and the systematic undoing of both are beneficial to the other (as both are considered as Othered in position).

The position of the woman in society lends itself to a discussion and approach to Architecture that is far beyond women themselves, but rather a systemic undoing of traditional practice. As suggested in the readings, the female approach is often that of collaborative engagement, more detail-oriented to the human proportion/scale, and less bound to certain design aesthetics/materials.

The trouble can arise in later interpretations of feminist discourse, wherein feminists are criticised for NOT boxing themselves into the Other position.

A set of principles or rules for the feminine can be equally limiting to women as the masculine still is.

It is ultimately freedom of choice for women that stands at the root of all feminist theory, and this must also include their decisions with regards to the Architectural profession - no matter what that may resemble.